



△ TAKING OFF

Short daily flights take flamingos to fresh water for drinking, but longer nocturnal journeys between strings of alkaline lakes may lead them to fly hundreds of miles.

▽ DIFFERENT DIETS

Constant begging by flamingo chicks stimulates adults to produce a rich "crop milk," which is regurgitated to feed their young. The brilliant pink colors of the adult plumage are derived from the diet of algae.



Great white pelican

Pelecanus onocrotalus

Great white pelicans feed in flocks, herding fish into shallow water inside a tightening arc. Billfuls of water and fish are scooped up—the water spills out, but the fish rarely escape and are swallowed whole. Pelicans are massive birds but

buoyant on water, and they are surprisingly elegant in the air, where they fly in synchronized lines, V-shapes, and huge flocks. In Africa, they will breed at any time of the year if the conditions are briefly favorable, nesting in colonies.



△ FISH SCOOP

A pelican's large, sensitive bill detects fish by touch. It then scoops up to 3 gallons (11 liters) of water, complete with prey, in its elastic pouch.

- ↔ 5–6 ft (1.4–1.8 m)
- ⚖ 22–24 lb (10–11 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish
- 🏠



Sub-Saharan Africa,
W. and S. Asia

Gray crowned crane

Balearica regulorum

This spectacular crane used to be a common sight in East Africa's savannas and farmland. It strides majestically, picking seedheads and taking grasshoppers, locusts, worms, frogs, and lizards when it can. It has the typical crane dancing displays involving deep, rhythmic bowing movements with outspread wings, leading to dramatic leaps up to 8 ft (2.5 m) high.

Gray crowned crane pairs stay together for life and have large breeding territories. They nest in marshy places, clearing a large space by stamping on vegetation and gathering it into a huge central mound with a shallow cup to hold up to four eggs. These hatch after a month and the chicks quickly leave the nest. By the time they are three months old, the young are half the weight of an adult, but well grown and able to fly.

pearl-gray
feathers on neck

◁ ELEGANT DESIGN

The crown of stiff golden feathers is shared only with the closely related black crowned crane (*B. pavonina*).

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.1 m)
- ⚖ 7–9 lb (3–4 kg)
- ⊗ Endangered
- 🐍 Reptiles, insects, worms
- 🏠



E. to
S. Africa

